fabled Krishna temple in Guruvayur on the first of every month (according to the Malayalam calendar) throughout his long life, and thousands do the same to the hilltop shrine to Ayyappa at Sabarimalai, or to Balaji at Tirumalai. Sometimes it is to a particular area where many temples abound: the temples to the nine planets at Kumbakonam, for instance. But quite often it can be an extensive circuit, such as the one my family undertook by car across southern India when I was fourteen, a three-week journey that enabled us to pray at Tirupati, Madurai (whose famed Meenakshi temple, dedicated to a warrior queen who became a consort of Shiva, boasts 33,000 sculptures), Thanjavur, Kanchipuram, Palani, Rameswaram and innumerable smaller towns in Tamil Nadu and Kerala, halting at each place just to worship at the principal temple, and moving on to the next one. My parents found this profoundly satisfying; for their children, it was all a bit of an adventure, though we learned a little about Hinduism at each stop.

The striking thing to a young boy during this journey was the remarkable variety of these places of worship, the differences in their architectural styles and physical appearances, the different manifestations of god being worshipped at different temples, the variety of rituals and the behaviour of the priests, the different materials presented as *prasadam* (offerings) to the gods, and the idiosyncratic practices associated with each shrine, most famously the shaving of the head at the Venkatachalapathi temple in Tirumalai, Tirupati (Andhra Pradesh), the richest temple in India,[7] where my fourteen-year-old locks were duly shorn as an offering to Lord Balaji.

The Hindu acceptance of variety goes much farther than this, however. Foreigners sometimes politely ask if Hinduism requires vegetarianism or abjures alcohol, and are puzzled when different Hindus give them different answers to the question. Versions of the faith come with their own prescriptions and proscriptions, but there is no universal requirement. There are Hindus, particularly Vaishnavas in the north, who recoil in horror at the very thought of consuming meat and others who will not touch even garlic or onion (considered *tamasik*[8] foods by purists), while there are Hindus who eat all of these and would consider it mildly uncivilised not to do so. Goats are routinely sacrificed at the